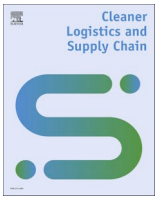
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Understanding the nexus between stakeholders and the success of local food supply chains: A systematic literature review

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ABSTRACT

The purpose of our study is to understand the nexus between stakeholders and the success of the local food supply chains (LFSCs). We conducted a systematic literature review (SLR) of 89 empirical papers to attain the research aim. Drawing on stakeholder theory, we have identified 12 distinct types of stakeholders that influence the development of LFSCs. We further categorized them into four groups (Players, Context setters, Subjects and Crowds) based on the power-interest matrix. Our analysis suggests that "Players" are the more significant stakeholders, followed by "Context setters". Furthermore, we have identified five roles - "initiator", "investor", "educator", "regulator", and "facilitator" that stakeholders play in the successful development of LFSCs. However, their role enactment is triggered by drivers (self-centric and altruistic) while delayed by barriers (endogenous and exogenous). To satisfy drivers and vanquish barriers, stakeholders engage with each other. All these aspects are symbiotic; disregard or obliviousness of any of these leads to the failure of such chains. This is the first SLR that has adopted stakeholder theoretical lens in categorizing stakeholders of LFSCs; thus, this research has broadened the scope of the theory and widened the knowledge base of the investigated phenomena. By categorizing roles and showing what roles are unique and shared, this research clarifies level of contributions of stakeholders in developing LFSCs. Additionally, this study contributes to practice. The identification of stakeholders, especially the categorization, provides insights into whom to prioritize and why. Thus, guides focal firm in managing stakeholders effectively. This research offers directories of roles, drivers, and barriers by different stakeholders and types of chains that focal firm can consider while developing LFSCs.

1. Introduction

Globalization of food supply chains has been embraced by society, which has been considered an option to enjoy a wide range of products at a lower price (Wang et al., 2022). However, in practice, this has never been cheap. The globalization of food supply chains has resulted in significant negative environmental, social, and economic consequences (Kalfagianni and Skordili, 2018; Galli et al., 2015). The growing awareness of the challenges linked to the global food supply chains has triggered the shift towards local food supply chains (LFSCs) (Enthoven and Van den Broeck, 2021). Furthermore, current geo-political situation has sparked interest in local food and LFSCs even higher. LFSCs are considered more sustainable since they integrate social and environmental issues with economic issues (e.g., Malak-Rawlikowska et al., 2019). Despite the interest in LFSCs and the acknowledgement of their contribution to sustainability, implementation of such chains has not been smooth, and many efforts have failed (e.g., Rucabado-Palomar and Cuéllar-Padilla, 2020; Halkier and James, 2022). One of the factors to success or failure of these chains is stakeholder management (Halkier and James, 2022). No single individual is responsible for the development of LFSCs, rather multiple individuals and organizations organize and implement such chains (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022). Hence management of these multiple entities become crucial for the success of LFSCs.

Stakeholders are individuals or groups who can influence or be influenced by the focal firm (Freeman, 1984). Stakeholders in LFSCs typically includes producers, customers, retailers, distributors, local and state government, activists, education institutions and so on (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022, Garcia-Gonzalez and Eakin, 2019; Miralles et al., 2017). However, the list of stakeholders in LFSCs varies, since no

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single consistent focal firms exist in LFSCs. They are configured in multiple ways by multiple actors. For instance, while some configurations are direct to end customers (e.g. community supported agriculture (CSA) and farm shops), others are intermediate to end customers (e.g. retailer, wholesaler, farm to institutions (FTI)) (Enthoven and Van den Broeck, 2021). Alongside, hybrid configurations exist where products and information flow directly from producers to end customers, however a third party coordinates these flows, for instance, digital platforms for local food (e.g. Viciunaite, 2023).

In these configurations focal firm varies depending on how and who coordinated the chains. For instance, in farm shop model, the producers typically act as focal firms as they coordinate the functions within the chain and customers are conceptualized as one of the stakeholders (e.g., Jönsson, 2026). Conversely in consumer -led CSA models, coordination role is shifted to the end customers as they organize the chain (e.g., Nováčková et al., 2026). In such instances, producers are theorized as one of the stakeholders, since they participate in the chain rather than directing it. Likewise, for intermediate chains, intermediaries, for instance, retailers, wholesalers, institutions, or restaurants are identified as focal firms, around which stakeholders (e.g. producers, customers) are organized. In hybrid configurations, the matchmaker (e.g. digital platform) becomes the focal firm around which different stakeholders (e.g., producers, customers) consolidate.

1.1. Research motivation

The aforementioned variability in focal firms necessitates explicit identification of a full range of stakeholders involved in LFSCs. Nonetheless, identification of a broader range of stakeholders can create a dilemma in deciding whom to prioritize over others (Wagner Mainardes et al., 2012). Prioritization of stakeholders is necessary, because their interest in, power to influence and roles in developing LFSCs vary. In extant literature, identified stakeholders remain scattered, moreover, does not provide insight into which stakeholders are more critical. For instance, Atkočiuniene et al. (2022) identified a wide range of stakeholders of LFSCs but did not categorize them, thus, what stakeholders of such chains should be prioritized over others is yet to be known **(Gap 1).**

Each LFSC configuration involves different combinations of stakeholders, hence, their interest in participating in certain configurations diverges from one another. Moreover, interests of same stakeholder can differ from one configuration to another. For instance, producers involved in CSA are often motivated by predicted sales (Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021), whereas in farmers market (FM), community building opportunities motivate them (O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015). This implies that stakeholders' interests are not limited to altruistic, rather can be self-seeking. Failure to address any of the interest types can pose threats instead of adding value (Susnienė and Purvinis, 2015), lead to resistance to participation (De Gooyert et al., 2017), poor performance, or even failure (Bryson, 2004; Bryson et al., 2011). Research so far has identified interests across stakeholders and configurations in isolation. In addition, only a few studies (e.g., Cumming et al., 2020) have distinguished interests as altruistic vs self-seeking. However, the studies are based on single LFSC configuration. Comparison of stakeholders' interest by different stakeholders and LFSC configurations would provide comprehensive understanding of how alike or divergent interests are within and across stakeholders as well as configurations. Alongside, distinguishing interests in altruistic vs self-seeking dimensions could assist in understanding which one is more salient across stakeholders and configurations. Hence, the current literature lacks a comprehensive understanding of stakeholders' interest and their effect on development of LFSCs **(Gap 2).**

Likewise, there is a lack of comprehensive understating of stakeholders' barriers to participate in LFSCs in the extant literature. Barriers identified across stakeholders and configurations are scattered in the literature. Alongside, there is little clarity in extant literature, regarding the extent to which barriers experienced by same stakeholder differ or align across LFSC configurations, as these barriers have largely been examined in separate studies. Moreover, extant literature provides limited insights regarding the source of barriers, whether external or internal. Hashem et al. (2018) has distinguished barriers in terms of internal and external, however, their findings are based on one type of LFSC. Distinguishing between internal and external barriers is necessary, since the strategies to overcome barriers that are internal to the stakeholders differ from that of external. Thus, extant literature provides limited insights into the stakeholders' barriers and their effect on development of successful LFSCs **(Gap 3)**.

Sustainable supply chain literature demonstrates that stakeholders play the role of initiator, facilitator, regulator, and inspector (Siems et al., 2023; Carmagnac, 2021; Liu et al., 2018). Stakeholders in LFSCs also play diverse roles in the development of LFSCs (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022). Previous studies explored stakeholders' roles in LFSCs; nevertheless, they did not categorize the roles (e.g., Atkočiuniene et al., 2022). Moreover, in LFSCs, some roles are shared, for instance, producers play the role of initiator in one configuration (e.g., farm shop), they become facilitators in other (e.g., CSA). As a result, there is limited conceptual clarity about how diverse stakeholders contribute to the development of LFSCs **(Gap 4).** The classification of roles by stakeholders would assist in distinguishing what roles are unique to a particular stakeholder and what roles are shared.

Given their diverse roles and asymmetric power positions, stakeholders need to depend on one another to support the development of LFSCs. Extant research demonstrates that stakeholder engagement is essential. However, there is limited information on which LFSC configuration requires intensive stakeholder engagement and whether similar engagement approaches are effective for all configurations **(Gap 5).**

A systematic literature review (SLR) has the potential to address these gaps by synthesizing and consolidating the findings that remain fragmented across the existing body of literature. Previous SLR on LFSCs have examined different aspects, including exploration of critical success factors to establish LFSCs (Saleh et al., 2025); local food business model innovation (Fobbe and Hilletofth, 2025), and investigation of common claims surrounding local food (Enthoven and Van den Broeck, 2021). However, these reviews have not specifically focused on stakeholders or the relationship between stakeholders and LFSCs. Therefore, by analyzing stakeholders of LFSCs and exploring the interplay between stakeholders and LFSCs, through the lens of stakeholder theory, this review contributes to the extant literature.

1.2. Research questions

To bridge the aforementioned knowledge gaps, we have set out the following research questions (RQ):

RQ1: Who are the stakeholders of LFSCs, and how can they be prioritized over one another?

RQ2: What roles do stakeholders play in the successful development of LFSCs?

RQ3: How do drivers and barriers of stakeholders align or differ across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development?

RQ4: How does stakeholder engagement approach align or differs across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development?

2. Background

2.1. Local food supply chain

Local food supply chain (LFSC) is characterized as alternative to the global food supply chain (GFSC), in which the distributed foods are spatially embedded and connected to the local community (Graciotti and McEachern, 2024). In other words, LFSCs distribute foods that are produced and consumed within the same spatial or geographical boundary (Saleh et al., 2025; Kusz and Kilar, 2020). The spatial or geographical boundary of localness can range from territory to national

border (e.g., Graciotti and McEachern, 2024; Banerjee and Quinn, 2022). LFSCs convey information about where, by whom and how the food was produced, hence, the end customers become connected and recognize the localness of the foods, even if they are delivered through intermediaries (King et al., 2014). This signifies that the notion of localness can go beyond the spatial proximity or geographical closeness to end customers (Chicoine et al., 2022). Foods can be considered local if it is proximate or close to end customers in terms of culture (Chicoine et al., 2022), identity (i.e. shared value between customers and those asserted by the products) (Graciotti and McEachern, 2024; Chicoine et al., 2022), relationship (e.g. close connection between actors) (Banerjee and Quinn, 2022; Chicoine et al., 2022), experience (e.g. pleasure), functionality (e.g. efficiency at the communicational level of the product) and process (e.g. methods used are shaped by the locality (Chicoine et al., 2022).

LFSCs can be shorter to wider within the national boundary (Graciotti and McEachern, 2024) and can be led by different stakeholders, resulting in direct and intermediate distribution (e.g., Belletti et al., 2024; Enthoven and Van den Broeck, 2021). Table 1 outlines the typology of LFSCs developed from the supply chain actor perspective (e.g. direct, intermediate) and product or information flow perspective within the supply chain (e.g. direct to customer, indirect to customer). Based on the 2 × 2 matrix, we have identified four categories of LFSCs: direct-direct, direct-intermediate, indirect-direct, and indirect-intermediate. Different configurations of LFSCs identified from the literature have been grouped under these four overarching categories (see Table 1).

In "*Direct-Direct (DD)*" chains, no other actors are involved between producer and customer, and the product or information flows directly from producers to end customers. For instance, in farm shop (producers selling their own farm produce in shop located on or near farm), and CSA (producer- and consumer- led) two actor groups are involved (e.g., producers and customers) and products/information flow directly from producers to customers (e.g., Nováčková et al., 2026; Jönsson, 2026; Rosol and Barbosa Jr., 2021). Thus, from both actor and flow perspective such configurations can be referred as "direct-direct" chains. Like the DD chains, in *"Indirect-direct (ID)"* chains, there are no third parties between producers and customers, however, certain customers act as representatives of member customers, and the product or information flows directly from the producers via the representatives of customers to the member customers. For instance, in consumer food cooperatives, single or group of customers collaborate with producers, receive products directly from producers and distribute among the member customers (e.g., Barcelos et al., 2026; Vittersø et al., 2019; Lake and Leviten-Reid, 2015). Here, only two groups of actors are involved in (i.e. producers and customers), hence from the actor perspective it is a direct chain, however, the product and information flow indirectly via the owner or organizer customers to the member customers. Thus, can be signified as indirect-direct (ID) chains.

In *"Direct-Intermediate (DIM)"* chains, a third party other than the producers or customers works as a middleman who arranges the supply chain and connects producers with customers. For instance, in (third party led) FM, a third party mediates the transaction between producers and customers through their governance structure that both participating groups must follow. However, product and information flow directly between producers and customers (e.g., Renkema-Singh and Hilletofth, 2025; Metz and Scherer, 2022). This signifies that from the actor perspective such configuration is intermediate, whereas, from the flow perspective, it is direct. Thereby can be referred to as direct-intermediate chain. *"Indirect-Intermediate (IIM)"* chains are similar to DIM except that the product or information flows from the producer to customers via the third party. For instance, mainstream wholesalers and retailers who purchase local food from producers and sales to customers (e.g., Roy et al., 2019; Zwart and Wertheim-Heck, 2021; Thomas et al., 2025). From the actor perspective such chains are intermediate as they are mediated by these third-party actors and from the flow perspective these chains are indirect since the product and information are transmitted indirectly from producers to customers. Thus, we have classified such configurations as indirect-intermediate.

Table 1
Typology of LFSCs, source: Author's own creation.

		ACTOR PERSPECTIVE	
		Direct	Intermediate
FLOW PERSPECTIVE	Direct	Direct -Direct (DD) ■ Farm shop (FS) ■ Community supported agriculture (CSA)	Direct-Intermediate (DIM) ■ Farmer market (FM) ■ Digital platforms (DP)
	Indirect	Indirect-Direct (ID) ■ Food cooperative (COOP) ■ Solidarity purchasing group (SPG) ■ Buying club (BC)	Indirect-Intermediate (IIM) ■ Grocery retailers (GR) ■ Local independent store (LIS) ■ Box scheme (BS) ■ Food hub (FH)/ Wholesalers ■ Farm to institution (FTI)/ Farm to food service (FTFS)

2.2. Stakeholder theory

Stakeholder theory (ST) defines stakeholders as any individual or group who can influence or be influenced by the focal firm (Freeman, 1984). Stakeholders are these groups or individuals without whose support, the organization or focal firm would fail to survive (Freeman, 1984), hence their identification is crucial for value creation and value capture (Mitchell and Lee, 2019). Freeman (1984) advocates identifying stakeholders from a broader perspective. According to the stakeholder theory, stakeholder can be both internal and external to the focal firm (Fritz et al., 2018). Siems et al. (2023), in their study, have reported that in sustainable supply chain management, focal firms' internal stakeholders include top management, employees and shareholders. External stakeholders range from suppliers (upstream stakeholders); customers, end users, retailers (downstream stakeholders); union, competitor, industry association (market stakeholder); and non-governmental organizations (NGOs), universities, government authorities (societal stakeholders).

The broader perspective in stakeholder identification often jeopardizes focal firms while deciding whom to prioritize over others (Wagner Mainardes et al., 2012). Hence, it becomes essential to categorize identified stakeholders. One of the stakeholder categorization methods is the power-interest (PI) matrix (e.g., Reed et al., 2009; Ackermann and Eden, 2011; Ackermann et al., 2024). Stakeholders acquire "power" through expertise, money, formal authority, voting rights, and regulatory authority (Bryson et al., 2011; Eden and Ackermann, 1998) which enables them to initiate certain actions (Ackermann et al., 2024). Stakeholders' "interests" encompass their objectives, aspirations, and concerns around the focal organizations (Ackermann et al., 2024; Bryson et al., 2011). By evaluating the stakeholders' level of influencing power and their level of interest in the organization, stakeholders can be categorized into four distinct groups: players, subjects, context setters, and crowds (e.g., Ackermann et al., 2024; Bryson et al., 2011; Ackermann and Eden, 2011; Reed et al., 2009, Bryson, 2004).

"Players" are those stakeholders who have substantial power to influence and have significant interest in a particular organization (Bryson et al., 2011; Eden and Ackermann, 1998). Another group of stakeholders who have high power to influence, however, have little direct interest in a particular organization are labelled as "Context setters" (Ackermann and Eden, 2011; Ackermann et al., 2024; Reed et al., 2009). In contrast, stakeholders with limited power to influence and high interest are considered as "Subjects". Stakeholders with both low interest and

power over the organization are referred as "Crowds" (Ackermann and Eden, 2011; Ackermann et al., 2024).

ST literature demonstrates that stakeholders play diverse roles in supply chains. Carmagnac (2021) reports that stakeholders, for instance, non-governmental organizations (NGOs) and local communities can play instigator or initiator role by exercising pressure and campaigning. Authors further reported that stakeholders can play the role of supporter by providing training; facilitator by connecting actors; and leader. These roles have also been identified in an earlier study by Liu et al. (2018). The authors have further referred to an additional role of stakeholder, namely inspector. Likewise, Siems et al. (2023) reported that stakeholders in sustainable supply chain management can play the role of driver, facilitator and inspector.

ST signifies that firms can satisfy self-interest (e.g., organizational success) by satisfying the interests of multiple stakeholders (De Gooyert et al., 2017). In other words, being unable to embrace their interest or drivers and acknowledge their roles often leads to poor performance and failure of focal firms (Bryson et al., 2011). Thus, the interests of stakeholders should be explored. However, the focal firms' perspectives on stakeholders' interests usually differ from stakeholders' perspectives on their interests, thus, engagement of stakeholders is necessary (De Gooyert et al., 2017; Bryson, 2004). Stakeholder engagement (SE) is practice of involving stakeholders in organizational activities (Greenwood, 2007). SE results in better financial performance for firms (Kujala et al., 2022), foster innovation, and increase legitimacy and trust in the focal firm (Sloan, 2009). SE further assists to build a long-term relationship with stakeholders (De Gooyert et al., 2017). Therefore, it is essential to engage stakeholders for the success of the focal firm (Reed et al., 2009). Stakeholder theory denotes several approaches to engage stakeholders. Stakeholders can be engaged for instance through dialogue, collaboration, co-creation and co-production (Kujala et al., 2022). Dialogue and collaboration enable mutual understanding, knowledge and resource sharing (Novoa et al., 2018; Shackleton et al., 2019; Kujala et al., 2022).

2.3. Stakeholder dynamics in local food supply chains

Previous studies have identified diverse array of stakeholders of local food supply chains. However, most of them have focused on limited types of stakeholders in one study. For instance, Vargas et al. (2026) included three types of stakeholders namely, restaurant chefs, farmers (producers) and public servants (government) to understand their perception of local food, their strategies and challenges in promoting local food consumption. Thus, the research misses the perception of one significant stakeholder, end customer. Conversely, Maró et al. (2026), in their research have explored factors influencing end customers' purchasing decision in farmers' market (FM). Thereby, the research overlooked other relevant stakeholders, for instance, producers, and organizers. Moreover, their research is focused on only one type of LFSC (i.e. FM) and lacks insight into the other types. Consequently, the identified stakeholders, their drivers, barriers in developing LFSCs remain scattered across the literature.

Additionally, there is lack of knowledge concerning to what extent the drivers are self-centric or altruistic, since most research has not classified or distinguished them. Classification of drivers into these dimensions is necessary since psychological literature suggests that individuals who are more self-centered participate in sustainable endeavor only if environmental or social benefit comes along with personal benefit. In contrast, altruistic individuals participate in such endeavors even if the personal benefits are absent (Simeone et al., 2025). Cumming et al. (2020), and Czudec (2022) are some exceptions who have distinguished self-centric and altruistic drivers of stakeholders. However, their research has focused either on one type of LFSCs or no specific types of such chains. Hence, they provide partial understanding of drivers of stakeholders in LFSCs. Similar gap is noticed in exploration of stakeholders' barriers in participating in LFSCs. Extant literature has not distinguished and compared the stakeholders' barriers to participation in terms of internal and external. As a result, there are inadequate understanding on whether their participation primarily hindered due to lack of internal capacity or external favorable context (e.g., Ben-Othmen and Kavouras, 2022; Dancer et al., 2019; Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021). Such distinction of internal and external barriers is essential since they are subject to different strategies. Internal barriers perhaps can be overcome through micro-level and meso- level actions such as collaboration with other stakeholders, knowledge sharing, whereas to overcome external barriers macro level interventions might be needed (e.g., policy reform). Furthermore, there is limited knowledge on how aligned or divergent the barriers across the types of stakeholders and LFSCs.

Sustainable supply chain literature illustrates stakeholders' contributions in the development of sustainable supply chain are more effectively realized if their roles are grouped based on their underlying functions (e.g., Siems et al., 2023). Current literature has identified the roles played by stakeholders in LFSCs, however ignored their categorization. Atkočiuniene et al. (2022), reported that "European commission" has stressed the categorization of stakeholders' roles, for instance, into facilitator, implementor, regulator, in order to have clear understanding of all stakeholders' contribution in developing LFSCs. Nevertheless, the authors themselves did not categorize the roles they identified in their study.

In addition, there is lack of understanding regarding whether the engagement approaches are consistent or vary across different types and whether similar levels of stakeholder engagement are required across different types. This is because previous research has investigated engagement approaches of single types of LFSCs (e.g., Balázs et al., 2016; Furness et al., 2022; Zoll et al., 2021).

SLR can connect all these dots dispersed across the extant literature. By bridging diverse empirical evidence, the review can provide a more comprehensive understanding of how stakeholder dynamics- roles, drivers, barriers and engagement aligns or differs across different LFSCs and contribute to their success. SLR will not only allow us to clarify conceptual ambiguity but also will demonstrate theoretically grounded future research avenue.

3. Research method

We have adopted systematic literature review (SLR) as a research method. SLR enabled us to explain the nexus between stakeholders and LFSC's success from different chain types, timelines, and geographical contexts. We followed the six-step process of conducting SLR in the supply chain management field proposed by Durach et al., 2017. This includes 1) defining research questions, 2) determining the required characteristics of primary studies, 3) retrieving a baseline sample of articles, 4) selecting the pertinent literature, 5) synthesizing the literature, and 6) reporting the results (Table 2).

First, research questions were defined based on the identified research gaps in existing literature. *Second,* the required characteristics (inclusion and exclusion criteria) were determined. We decided to include articles written in English language to avoid any misunderstanding during the translation process. Only peer reviewed journals were included to ensure reliability and scientific credibility. We excluded conceptual and literature review paper and grounded our research only on empirical papers to avoid the synthesis of already synthesized papers and normative interpretation. We wanted to ensure that conclusions were drawn from first-order data and not from second-order data. We furthermore excluded non-profit models since they have different logic than the profit-oriented models, which perhaps made the comparison irrelevant.

Third, we selected multiple data sources that were considered in retrieving a baseline sample of articles, since they increase the data quality (Tranfield et al., 2003). Both selected databases contain a wide range of high-quality journals (Koutsos et al., 2019; Paul et al., 2021). A relevant search string was developed for each database (Table 2). The

Table 2
Six-step process of developing and conducting SLR based on Durach et al. (2017).

Step 1: Determining the research question

- This paper aims to explain the nexus among the stakeholders and the success of local food supply chains (LFSCs), hence, we formulated the research question (RQ): 1) Who are the stakeholders of LFSCs, and how can they be prioritized over one another? 2) What roles do stakeholders play in the successful development of LFSCs? 3) How do drivers and barriers of stakeholders align or differ across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development? 4) How does stakeholder engagement approach align or differs across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development?

Step 2: Determining the required characteristics of primary studies

- To avoid selection and selector bias, the research team discussed and agreed upon the eligibility criteria (Durach et al., 2017). To be included in the review, the articles must i) be written in the English language, ii) published in a peer-reviewed journal iii) be an empirical study, iv) not centered on a non-profit model of LFSC (e.g., community garden), and v) cover at least two of the research questions.
- Articles that did not meet these criteria were excluded.

Step 3: Retrieve a baseline sample of articles

- Two online databases Scopus and Web of Science (WOS) have been used to search for articles.
- Two separate search strings were developed for the mentioned databases.
- Scopus: (TITLE-ABS-KEY (“alternative food supply chain” OR “alternative food network” OR “short food supply chain” OR “local food supply chain” OR “local food system” OR “local food initiative”) AND TITLE-ABS-KEY (“role” OR “function” OR “activit” OR “task” OR “benefit” OR “value” OR “success” OR “failure” OR “driver” OR “motiv”OR “barrier” OR “challenge” OR “hinder” OR “enabler” OR “facilitator” OR “cooperation” OR “collaboration” OR “engagement”)) AND (LIMIT-TO (SRCTYPE, “j”)) AND (LIMIT-TO (DOCTYPE, “ar”)) AND (LIMIT-TO (LANGUAGE, “English”))
- WOS: “alternative food supply chain” or “alternative food network” or “short food supply chain” or “local food supply chain” or “local food system” or “local food initiative” (Topic) and “role” or “function” or “activit”or “task” or “benefit”or “value” or “success”or “driver” or “motive” or “failure” or “barrier” or “challenge”or “hinder” or “enabler” or “facilitator” or “cooperation” or “collaboration” or “engagement” (Topic) and Article (Document Types) and English (Languages)
- Search resulted in a total number of 2415 hits, of which 1271 were from Scopus and 1144 were from WOS.
- Database alerts were set to get notified of any potential new articles.

Step 4: Apply the inclusion and exclusion criteria from step 2

- No. of articles after duplicate removal: 1434
- No. of articles after abstract assessment: 517
- 517 papers were read in full text. Eligibility criteria were further applied to select the relevant papers. While any confusion occurred about the relevance of an article, the authors discussed it among themselves to reach a transparent decision. This led to a sample of 89 articles.

Step 5: Synthesize the articles

- Quantitative analysis: Descriptive analysis was conducted to understand the trend.
- Qualitative analysis: Synthesizing the content of the samples through content analysis.

Step 6: Report the results of the SLR

- A descriptive overview of the reviewed literature is first presented.
- Findings generated from the content analysis are then presented to answer the research questions.

final search was conducted in November 2024. The search alert was turned on for both databases to get notifications of any potential new articles.

Fourth, while selecting relevant literature from the base line sample, the authors discussed it among themselves to reach a transparent decision, if there was any confusion about the relevance of an article. This led to a selection of 89 articles. Fifth, descriptive and content analysis were conducted to synthesize the articles. Sixth, they are reported to answer the research questions.

4. Results

4.1. Descriptive analysis

A descriptive analysis of different types of LFSCs has been conducted (Fig. 1). Total count of articles for each LFSC type observed in the selected sample is presented. To denote these LFSCs types as per the typology presented in the background section, we have marked the similar types using analogous colors. Four distinct colors represent four overarching types of LFSCs (see Table 1). The analysis shows that the total of 37 papers has investigated “Direct-Intermediate (DIM)” chains - FM (29) and DP (8). 33 papers have analyzed “Indirect-Intermediate” (IIM) chains- FTI/FTFS (13), BS (12), GR (7), and FH (1). “Indirect-Direct” (ID) chains such as COOP (11), BC (3), and SPG (2) has been investigated by a total of 16 papers. Furthermore, a total of 25 papers analyzed “Direct-Direct” (DD) chains - CSA (18) and FS (7). This analysis shows that intermediate LFSCs holds most interest among researchers. However, limited research has been conducted on mainstream intermediaries (e.g., GR, wholesalers), and FH. Likewise, research on digital intermediaries, specifically, DP (digital platforms) is scant. Hence more research needs to be conducted on these intermediate chains.

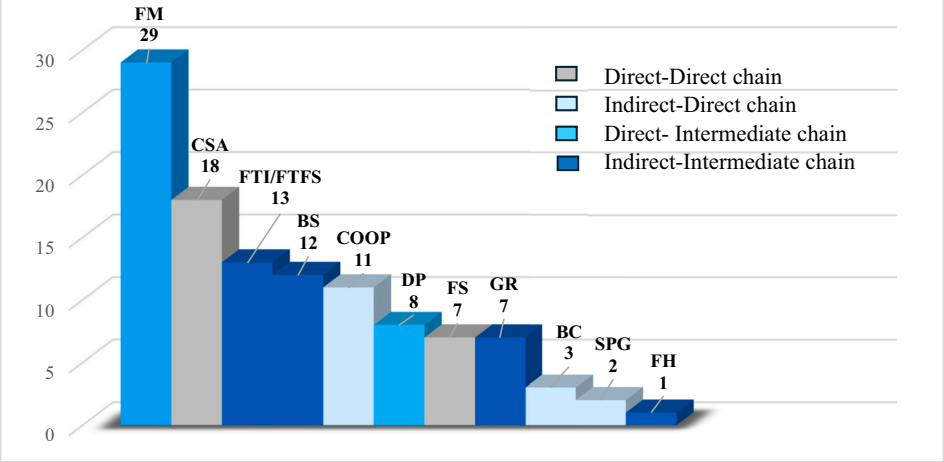


Fig. 1. Type of LFSCs identified by the number of articles, Source: Author's own creation.

4.2. Content analysis

4.2.1. Stakeholder identification and categorization

By systematically reviewing literature, we have identified 12 distinct types of stakeholders of LFSCs, as presented in Table 3. The table also reports the frequency with which each stakeholder appears across the reviewed literature, reflecting their prominence in the extant literature. However, these stakeholders differ in terms of their relative power and level of interest in the focal firm's operation (e.g., Eden and Ackermann, 1998). Hence, all stakeholders are not subject to equal attention and prioritization for focal firm. They need to be categorized so that one can be prioritized over another. The identified stakeholders have been classified into four groups- "Players", "Subjects", "Context setters" and "Crowds" based on the power-interest matrix (Fig. 2). The frequency of occurrence demonstrates that "Players" (168) are of significantly important followed by "Context setters" (38), "Subjects" (29), and "Crowds" (16). Each group has been explained in the subsequent section.

"Players" group encompasses of five stakeholders presented in the Table 3, namely producers, end customers, retailers, restaurants and organizers. Our analysis shows that all of them have high interest in participating in the LFSCs and higher influencing power. For instance, unlike in GFSCs, in LFSCs, producers have greater work autonomy (Darolt et al., 2016), decision-making authority, and flexibility (Zoll et al., 2021; Zwart and Wertheim-Heck, 2021). In addition, they exhibit higher interest and motivation to participate in the LFSCs (e.g., Hvitsand and Leikvoll, 2023; Atkočiuniene et al., 2022). Likewise, customers, retailers, restaurants exhibit significant interest in the LFSCs (e.g., Godrich et al., 2020; Lombardi et al., 2015). They can exert high power, as they make informed purchasing decisions (Cox et al., 2008; Torjusen et al., 2008), participate in co-production, provide working capital, and have rights to vote on decisions (e.g., Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020; Balázs et al., 2016). Organizers of LFSCs also fall in this group, since they hold a direct interest (e.g., Hvitsand and Leikvoll, 2023; Warsaw et al., 2022), and have the superior formal authority to make management-related decisions (e.g., Hvitsand and Leikvoll, 2023; Buckley et al., 2013).

Five other identified stakeholders - farmer union, wholesaler (distributor), processor (aggregator), activists, NGOs (civil society) are categorized as "Subjects". Farmer union demonstrates a notable interest in strengthening the capacity of local producers through various initiatives but often lack the formal authority to generate a substantial impact (e.g., Schreiber et al., 2023). Similarly, aggregators, distributors, NGOs, and activists display interest in supporting LFSC-related operations, however, they act only in response to the demand of other stakeholders and lack power (e.g., Heiss et al., 2015; Van Gameren et al., 2015).

The another identified stakeholder, namely state and local government generally exhibit less interest in developing the LFSCs (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022; Lu and Carter, 2023). However, owing to their regulatory authority and access to resources (e.g., Zivkovic et al., 2022; Atkočiuniene et al., 2022), they have considerable power to influence. They can make the operating context favorable or unfavorable for LFSCs. Hence, we have categorized state and local governments as "Context setters".

In the context of LFSCs, educational institutions like schools and universities are deemed "Crowds". Their power is limited to transferring knowledge through training and research-based knowledge to the practitioners in LFSCs (e.g., Lu and Carter, 2023; Block et al., 2008). Moreover, these knowledge transfer initiatives are not solely directed by the institutions to the practitioners (Block et al., 2008), and their participation in developing LFSCs is minimal (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022). This suggests relatively little interest on their part.

Table 3
Stakeholders in LFSCs and their frequency of occurrence by article, Source: authors' own creation.

Stakeholders	Frequency
Producer	73
Customer	52
State and Local government	38
Organizer	21
Educational Institution	16
Retailer	14
Restaurant	8
NGO/Civil society	7
Aggregator/Processor	6
Farmers' Union	6
Distributor/Wholesaler	5
Activists	5

4.2.2. Roles of stakeholders

Drawing upon stakeholder theoretical lens, our study reveals that aforementioned four stakeholder groups perform five distinct roles: initiator, investor, educator, regulator, and facilitator in the development of LFSCs.

Initiator.

Initiator refers to the role of taking initiative to develop LFSCs. Producers and customers from the "Players" cohort often initiate and manage "direct -direct" (DD), and "indirect-direct" (ID) LFSCs (e.g., Atkočiuniene et al., 2022; Fuentes and Fuentes, 2022). Customers, for instance, in consumer-led CSA reach out to producers, contribute to labor (Furness et al., 2022), and distribute the share of the food among other members (Zoll et al., 2021). In contrast, other stakeholders in

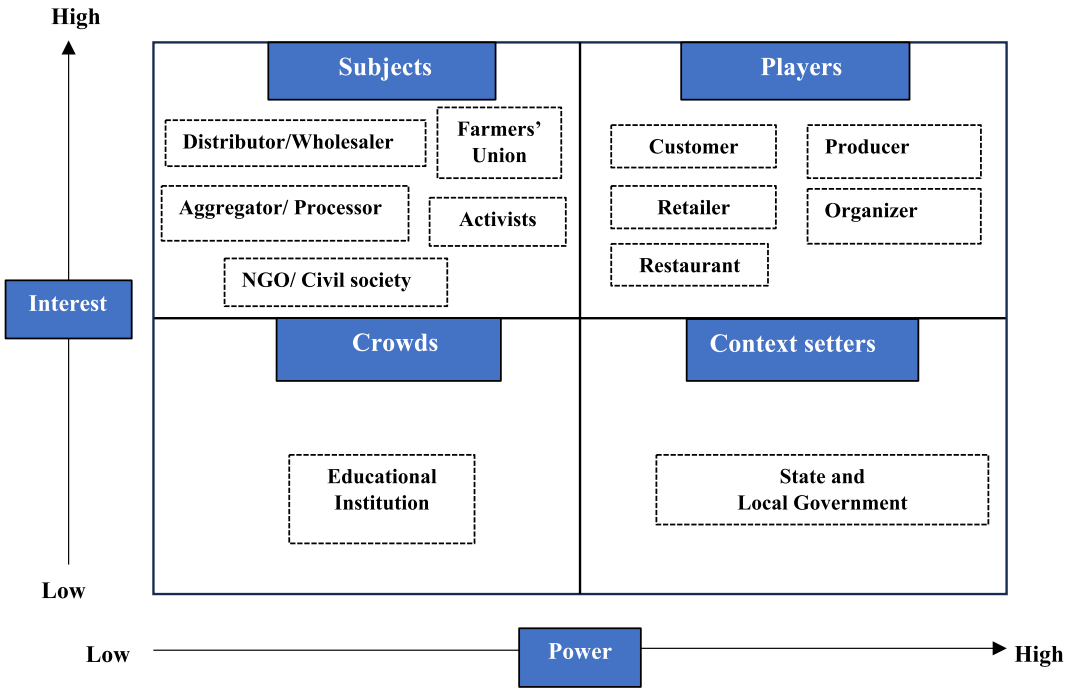


Fig. 2. Categorization of stakeholders, adapted from Eden and Ackermann (1998, 2011).

"Players" groups such as organizers, retailer and restaurant mostly initiate direct-intermediate (DIM) and indirect-intermediate (IIM) LFSCs. To exemplify, in FM, organizers secure physical space, invite producers or vendors (Warsaw et al., 2022), and do marketing to the local community (e.g., O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015). Likewise, restaurants and retailers, contact local food producers, change sourcing practice, improvise menus to adapt seasonal variations of local foods (e.g. Sharma et al., 2014; Zwart and Wertheim-Heck, 2021).

Investor.

The role of investor refers to investing financial and non-financial resources for the development of LFSCs. "Players" group is primarily responsible for financial investments essential for the operation of all configurations of LFSCs. For instance, in CSA, customers invest in a farm or crop before the harvest, thereby sharing the risk of production-related losses (Cox et al., 2008; Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020). In producer led initiatives (e.g., farm shops) producers typically arrange initial capital through personal savings or by reaching out to friends and family to cover production-related costs (e.g., Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020; Schreiber et al., 2023). In contrast, "Context setters" such as governments often invest indirectly for the development of LFSCs, for instance, they invest in food assistance programs so that fringe income groups can access local food from FM and allocate budgets for FTI (e.g., Lu and Carter, 2023; Zerbian et al., 2022). Furthermore, "Subjects" can involve in non-financial investments, such as farmers' unions often invest in marketing efforts, consequently supporting the development of LFSCs (e.g., Schreiber et al., 2023).

Educator.

The role of educator pertains to sharing information and knowledge with others. All stakeholder groups play the role of educator. "Players", for instance, producers can educate private customers, about sustainable and seasonal diets and local food production systems (Balázs et al., 2016) at the time of sale (O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015), or by offering farm visits (O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015; Torjusen et al., 2008) in FM and CSA respectively. In the BS, organizers (player) educate private customers by sending newsletters and information leaflets that provide information about products, harvesting, the context of food production, and recipes for cooking unknown varieties (Torjusen et al., 2008). While these "Players" act as informal educators, the "Crowd" (e.g. educational institutions) fulfill the role of formal educators. Curricula at universities, high schools, and schools that concentrate on food and nutrition can increase knowledge pertaining to local food and LFSCs (e.g., Block et al., 2008; Lu and Carter, 2023). Furthermore, "Context setters" such as the government can play a crucial role in educating the customers and farmers about the benefits of the local food system by arranging training and workshops (e.g., Kurtsal et al., 2020; Fair et al., 2023).

Regulator.

Regulator role defines the ability to regulate the operation of LFSCs. The regulator role is exclusively performed by "Context setters" (i.e., state and local governments). They have the power to shape and reshape the context within which the LFSCs operate through setting rules and regulations. For instance, laws governing the construction of permanent or semi-permanent structures (e.g., farmstands or stalls) may impede the development of LFSCs, for instance, FM (e.g., Dancer et al., 2019). Moreover, the government has the power to implement policies that prioritize the local food system (Zerbian et al., 2022; Zivkovic et al., 2022). A practical example would be setting a policy that mandates a certain percentage of locally sourced products in school meals and hospitals (e.g.,Zerbian et al., 2022; Smaal, 2023). This can greatly benefit the development of "Indirect-Intermediate (IIM)" LFSCs (i.e., FTI/FTFS).

Facilitator.

Facilitator denotes the action of supporting value creation within LFSCs in an indirect manner. "Context setters" (i.e., government) act as a facilitator in developing the LFSCs (e.g., Zerbian et al., 2022), since they have myriads of resources and power to influence (Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021). For instance, due to the easy access to resources, the government can allocate more vacant city land for production (González-Azcárate et al., 2023a), and distribution of local food (Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021). Additionally, the government can provide technological assistance (e.g., WIFI access) in the FM to enable payment acceptance through food assistance programs (Lu and Carter, 2023). Our analysis further demonstrates that "Subjects" (e.g., aggregators, NGOs, farmer unions) can act as facilitators. Aggregators, for instance, can support the development of "Indirect-Intermediate (IIM)" LFSCs (i.e., FTI/FTFS) by providing necessary storage or distribution-related infrastructures (e.g., Heiss et al., 2015). Likewise, NGOs can facilitate the establishment of

the IIM chains by promoting them to a broader group of the public (e.g., Buckley et al., 2013).

4.2.3. Stakeholders' drivers and barriers

Since, "Players" (producers, end customers, retailers, restaurants, organizers) and "Context setters" (state and local government) are more frequently pronounced in the literature, their drivers and barriers have been investigated most while drivers and barriers of other stakeholders have been ignored in the literature. Hence, we have only analyzed drivers and barriers of "Players" and "Context setters" in our study. Furthermore, we have included four types of chains (FM, CSA, FTI/FTS, BS) and overlooked rest, in our content analysis, since they have been mentioned most in the reviewed literature as per the descriptive analysis (see Fig. 1). These LFSC types are sub-types of three overarching types - DIM, DD and IIM respectively (see Table 1).

4.2.3.1. Drivers. Our analysis demonstrates that stakeholders exhibit self-centric drivers (SCD) and altruistic drivers (ALD). A comparison of drivers of "Players" stakeholder groups across the 4 different types of LFSCs, is presented in Table 4. However, comparison of drivers of "Context setters" across the four types was not possible since extant literature explored their drivers in developing LFSCs regardless of their types. Hence, we presented them as type independent in Table 4.

Producers exhibit higher level of self-centric drivers (SCD), while participating in direct-direct (DD) and direct-intermediate (DIM) chains (e.g., Demartini et al., 2017; Hvitsand and Leikvoll, 2023; Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021; Zoll et al., 2021; Beingessner and Fletcher, 2020; Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021; Neulinger et al., 2020) in comparison to other stakeholders. They also display altruistic drivers (ALD) (e.g., Warsaw et al., 2022; Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020), however, SCD are two times more prevalent than their altruistic drivers as reported in Table 4. This implies that those self-centric drivers are of their significant considerations while participating in LFSCs, specifically DD and DIM chains.

Likewise, end customers also demonstrate greater SCD than ALD to participate in LFSCs (e.g., Leiper and Clarke-Sather, 2017; Crawford et al., 2018; Hashem et al., 2018; Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020). However, they are driven by higher number of ALD than SCD while developing DD chains, for instance, CSA (e.g. Cox et al., 2008). In contrast, they are mostly driven by SCD than ALD while participating in indirect-intermediate (IIM) chains, specifically BS (e.g., Hashem et al., 2018; Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021; Leiper and Clarke-Sather, 2017; Crawford et al., 2018; Milestad et al., 2010).

In line with two other stakeholders, restaurants are more inclined to satisfy their SCD when participating in IIM chains like FTFS (e.g. Sharma et al., 2014; Smaal, 2023). Conversely, organizers place a higher emphasis on ALD than SCD, while participating in LFSCs chains, specifically, DIM chains like FM (e.g., O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015; Warsaw et al., 2022). Similarly, governments as "Context setters" tend to prioritize ALD over SCD while developing LFSCs (e.g., Lu and Carter, 2023; Zerbian et al., 2022; Aggestam et al., 2017).

4.2.3.2. Barriers. Our analysis shows that stakeholders are hindered by both internal and external context. Therefore, we have categorized them as endogenous barriers (EB) and exogenous barriers (XB) respectively. A comparison of barriers of "Players" stakeholder groups across the 4 different types of LFSCs, is presented in Table 5. Barriers of "Context setters" are reported regardless of types due to the reason mentioned in previous sub-section.

Our analysis shows that producers encounter mostly exogeneous barriers (XB) in comparison to endogenous barriers (EB) while participating in LFSCs, no matter if they are direct or intermediate chains. XB mostly originates from unfavorable policy and infrastructure (Mert-

Table 4
Drivers influencing stakeholder participation across different LFSC types, Source: Author's own creation.

Stakeholder groups		Drivers	DIM / FM	DD / CSA	IIM / FTI/FTFS	BS	Type-independent
Players	Producer	Fair price *(SCD1)*	✓	✓	✓	✓	
		Predictable sales *(SCD2)*		✓			
		Secure income through diversifying sales portfolio *(SCD3)*		✓			
		Decision-making power *(SCD4)*	✓	✓			
		Suitable location *(SCD5)*	✓				
		Saving time *(SCD6)*		✓			
		Less complexity, commitment, and high flexibility *(SCD7)*	✓			✓	
		Sense of recognition *(SCD8)*	✓				
		Customer trust *(SCD9)*	✓	✓			
		Building community and relationship *(ALD1)*	✓				
		Increasing access to and knowledge about local food *(ALD2)*	✓	✓	✓		
		Solidarity with fellow producers *(ALD3)*	✓				
		Environmental concern *(ALD4)*	✓	✓			
	Customer	Fresh and healthy products *(SCD1)*	✓	✓		✓	
		Less time and effort *(SCD2)*				✓	
		Direct communication and learning opportunities *(SCD3)*	✓	✓			
		Traceability *(SCD4)*	✓	✓		✓	
		Supporting local producers *(ALD1)*	✓	✓		✓	
		Building community *(ALD2)*		✓			
		Environmental Concern *(ALD3)*	✓	✓		✓	
	Restaurant	Fresh and quality products *(SCD1)*			✓		
		Product uniqueness *(SCD2)*			✓		
		Competitive price *(SCD 3)*			✓		
		Supporting local economy *(ALD 1)*			✓		
		Environmental sustainability *(ALD2)*			✓		
	Organizer	Economic Success *(SCD1)*	✓			✓	
		Fresh and healthy products *(SCD2)*			✓		
		Promoting local foods and producers *(ALD1)*	✓	✓	✓	✓	
		Educating customers *(ALD2)*	✓				
		Fostering equity *(ALD3)*	✓				
Context Setters	Government	Economic development *(SCD1)*					✓
		Rural development *(ALD1)*					✓
		Promoting local production *(ALD2)*					✓
		Reducing food poverty and insecurity *(ALD3)*					✓

Table 5
Barriers influencing stakeholder participation across different LFSC types, Source: Author's own creation.

Stakeholder groups		Barriers	*DIM* / *FM*	*DD* / *CSA*	*IIM* / *FTI/ FTFS*	/ *BS*	*Type-independent*
Players	Producer	Limited capacities *(EB1)*	✓	✓		✓	
		Norms and perception *(EB2)*	✓				
		Lack of infrastructure *(XB1)*	✓	✓	✓	✓	
		Unfavorable governmental requirements *(XB2)*	✓	✓	✓		
		Seasonal variation in customer demand *(XB3)*	✓				
		Lack of flexibility *(XB4)*	✓			✓	
		Lack of awareness *(XB5)*	✓				
	Customer	Limited affordability *(EB1)*			✓		
		Perception of food quantity *(EB2)*				✓	
		Price sensitivity *(EB3)*		✓	✓	✓	
		Seasonality *(XB1)*		✓		✓	
		Less diversity in the product *(XB2)*		✓		✓	
		Inconvenience *(XB3)*		✓		✓	
	Restaurant	Lack of knowledge *(EB1)*			✓		
		Require more time and effort *(EB2)*			✓		
		Lack of constant availability *(XB1)*			✓		
		Limited resources *(EB1)*		✓	✓		
		Difficulties in coordination *(EB2)*				✓	
		Lack of top management support *(EB3)*			✓		
		Lack of infrastructure *(EB4)*		✓			
		Finding customers *(XB1)*		✓			
	Organizer	Data Fatigue *(XB2)*	✓				
Context Setters	Government	Ignorance and reluctance *(EB1)*					✓
		Varied goals *(EB2)*					✓
		Limited financial and human resources *(EB3)*					✓
		Lack of local producers *(XB1)*					✓

Cakal and Miele, 2020; Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021; Zivkovic et al., 2022; and Zoll et al., 2021). XB can also arise from knowledge limitation of end customers (e.g., Kurtsal et al., 2020; Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021).

End customers experience greater number of XB than EB while participating in direct-direct (DD) and "indirect- intermediate" (IIM) chains such as CSA and BS respectively. Customers' XB ranges from seasonality, lack of diversity to inconvenience (e.g., Chen et al., 2019; Galt et al., 2019). These factors acted as barriers for end customers, due to the strong social norms positioned by the global food chains that diversified products can be accessed round the year at a convenient time and location (Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021; Galt et al., 2019). On the contrary, institutional customers are more influenced by EB. For instance, budget constraints of institutional buyers hinder the development of IIM (FTI/FTFS) chains (Heiss et al., 2015). Likewise, restaurants experience higher number of EB in developing LFSCs, due to the consequence of social norms stated earlier. Their notable XB to participate in LFSCs is lack of constant availability of local food (e.g., Smaal, 2023).

Organizers also experience higher number of EB while developing different types of LFSCs. Limited resources, lack of management support, difficulties in coordinating supplies and lack of infrastructure are their notable EB (e.g. Mert-Cakal and Miele, 2020; Milestad et al., 2017; Heiss et al., 2015). Government's ability to participate in the creation of LFSCs is constrained by both EB and XB. One of the prominent EB of governments is the ignorance or reluctance to involve in the local food systems (e.g., Lu and Carter, 2023; Emas and Jones, 2022; González-Azcárate et al., 2023a). Furthermore, the varied goals across governmental departments behind their participation in LFSCs (Lu and Carter, 2023) and lack of financial and human resources slows down the willingness of local government to foster the development of LFSCs (e.g., Emas and Jones, 2022; González-Azcárate et al., 2023a). XB that hinders their participation is lack of local producers (Beingessner and Fletcher, 2020).

4.2.4. Stakeholder engagement

As the stakeholder groups have varied power, their engagement with each other can assist in satisfying their drivers and overcoming barriers. Widely adopted stakeholder engagement (SE) approaches reported across our reviewed literature include communication, collaboration and co-creation (Table 6).

Indirect-intermediate (IIM) chains, specifically BS, adopt all three approaches to engage producers which assist in scaling up (e.g. Milestad et al., 2017). For example, BS co-create value with producers through involving them in decision making and collaborate with producers by exchanging resources (e.g. Milestad et al., 2017). Likewise, in FTFS (IIM chains), producers are engaged through establishing dialogue. For instance, producers are asked to communicate the story behind production to the restaurant chefs (e.g., Smaal, 2023). Moreover, in FTFS chains, producers are engaged in menu co-creation with restaurant chefs (e.g., Smaal, 2023). In direct- intermediate (DIM) chains, specifically FM, producers are engaged through face-to-face communication and dialogue with customers (e.g., O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015).

In FM, and BS, customers are engaged largely through communication during the sales, farm visits, newsletters and weekly meetings arrangements (e.g., O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015; Milestad et al., 2017). In direct-direct (DD) chains, for instance in CSA, alongside communication, customer members are engaged through co-production (e.g., Cox et al., 2008; Balázs et al., 2016; Furness et al., 2022; Zoll et al., 2021). This communication and co-production enable customers (members) to get insights into seasonality, and the production process (Cox et al., 2008; Torjusen et al., 2008) which helps them to accept seasonal unavailability.

In BS and FM, organizers get engaged with customers and producers through communicating newsletters and arranging meetings respectively (e.g., Milestad et al., 2017; O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015). Alongside, organizers in these chains engage producers through collaboration and value co-creation (e.g., Milestad et al., 2017; O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015).

In FTFS chains, restaurants chefs are engaged in direct communication with producers and customers. They communicate the story behind the production shared by producers among the restaurant guests. Such story telling is highly appreciated by customers, which convince chefs to continue buying local food (e.g., Smaal, 2023). Likewise, governments

Table 6
Stakeholder engagement approaches across different LFSC types, Source: Author's own creation.

Stakeholder groups		Engagement approaches	*DIM*	*DD*	*IIM*		*Type-independent*
			FM	*CSA*	*FTI/ FTFS*	*BS*	
Players	Producer	Communication	✓	✓	✓	✓	
		Collaboration				✓	
		Co-creation			✓	✓	
	Customer	Communication	✓	✓	✓	✓	
		Collaboration					
		Co-creation		✓			
	Restaurant	Communication			✓		
		Collaboration					
		Co-creation			✓		
	Organizer	Communication	✓			✓	
		Collaboration				✓	
		Co-creation				✓	
Context Setters	Government	Communication					✓
		Collaboration					
		Co-creation					

are engaged in exchanging dialogue with different stakeholders, and such dialogue can increase governments' willingness to undertake actions favorable to LFSCs (González-Azcárate et al., 2023a).

5. Discussion

We have discussed the findings of our review by the four RQs mentioned earlier in the subsequent section:

RQ1: Who are the stakeholders of LFSCs, and how can they be prioritized over one another?

The analysis reveals that LFSCs typically encompass a total of 12 distinct types of stakeholders, who can be either internal or external to the organization. We have categorized these stakeholders based on their power and interest so that they can be effectively managed. Out of the four stakeholder groups, "Players" are the most significant, followed by "Context setters", in terms of power and influence. Management of focal firms in the LFSCs should prioritize the "Players" most (e.g., Ackermann and Eden, 2011) and actively groom them (e.g., Reed et al., 2009) in order to retain their interest. Due to high influencing power but a lack of interest, "Context setters" can create challenges for the focal organization (Bryson et al., 2011). For instance, governments (Context setters) due to their low interest, might not realize the need for setting policy that supports the development of LFSCs. Hence, management should develop strategies to increase the interest of these "Context setters". While two latter stakeholder groups, namely Subjects and Crowds, are not as critical as the former two groups, they still require effective management. Because, "Subjects" might increase their power by collaborating with more powerful stakeholders (Reed et al., 2009), thus can exert greater influence on the development of LFSCs. Furthermore, it is also important to appropriately manage "Crowds" (e.g., educational institutions), since collaboration with them helps LFSCs to gain legitimacy and research insights (Poças Ribeiro et al., 2021).

RQ 2: What roles stakeholders play in the successful development of LFSCs?

Our findings denote that the stakeholders perform five roles (initiator, investor, regulator, facilitator and educator) in the development of LFSCs. "Players" group performs the majority of the identified roles, namely, initiator, investor, and educator. They are the sole contributors to the initiation of most of the chains. However, the role of investor can also be performed by "Context setters" and "Subjects". Likewise, the role of educator is shared with other stakeholder groups, , for instance, "Context setters" and "Crowds". These stakeholder groups can provide education in more formal manner. Among these five identified roles, the regulator role is exclusively associated with the "Context setters" and cannot be undertaken by any other groups. As "Players" and "Context setters" are unique contributors to certain roles, their interest must be satisfied in the first place for the successful development of such LFSCs. The interest of "Subjects" and "Crowds" should be considered afterwards to facilitate seamless development of the LFSCs.

RQ 3: How do drivers and barriers of stakeholders align or differ across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development?

It is evident in our study that stakeholders' drivers and barriers differ depending on the LFSC configurations. Moreover, drivers and barriers differ from one stakeholder to another. It is noteworthy that all the stakeholders (e.g. producers, customers, restaurants) except organizer, in "Players" group, prioritize self-centric drivers (SCD) over altruistic drivers (ALD), while participating in LFSCs. However, customers concentrate on satisfying ALD, while participating in "direct-direct" (DD) chains, specifically, CSA. As CSA requires higher level of commitment, it has been documented that CSA members who place greater value on saving time and effort (SCD 2) are less likely to renew their subscription (Galt et al., 2019). Consequently, this preference can negatively affect the success of CSA. However, the same driver can result in success for BS as its greater convenience better aligns with such customers.

Unlike other stakeholders, drivers of government (Context setters) have not been explored by the different types of LFSCs in the extant literature. This is perhaps because they lack a deep interest in participating LFSCs (Atkočiuniene et al., 2022; Lu and Carter, 2023). Management of different LFSC configurations should promote how the chains can contribute to the country's or region's economic and rural development, to garner the support of the "context setters".

Although management satisfies the interests of stakeholder groups, they might not play their expected roles in the successful development of LFSCs due to the internal and external barriers they encounter. With the exception of organizers and restaurants, stakeholders categorized as "Players" (producers, customers) are mostly impeded by exogeneous barriers (XB) while participating in any of the chains under investigations. In contrast, "Context setters" face more endogenous barriers (EB) while participating in LFSCs. Therefore, addressing both EB and XB is essential to enable stakeholders to fulfill their expected roles in developing LFSCs.

RQ 4: How does stakeholder engagement approach align or differs across types of LFSCs and influence their successful development?

Our research signifies that most common engagement approach across LFSC types is communication or dialogue. Producers and customers are engaged more in comparison to other types of stakeholders for the development of LFSCs. This is perhaps because they are start and end point of supply and demand respectively. The development of indirect-intermediate (IIM) chains such as BS and FTFS require greater engagement from diverse stakeholders (e.g., producers, customers,

restaurants and organizers). These chains involve multiple actors, which might increase complexity, requiring higher collaboration and communication. In contrast, direct-direct (DD) chains, for instance, CSA, require higher level of engagement from customers, as they often play a central role in initiating and sustaining such chains.

It is evident in our study that SE approaches can assist in overcoming barriers of stakeholders in the development of LFSCs. For instance, communicating information about producers and product can increase customers' knowledge of local food system, thereby contributing to a shift in established consumption norms from expecting year-round product availability to embracing seasonal availability (e.g., O'Kane and Wijaya, 2015; Milestad et al., 2017; Van Vlaanderen et al., 2021). Thus, SE can assist customers in overcoming their XB (1) reported in Table 5. Moreover, communication can satisfy producers' ALD (1 and 2) and customers' SCD (3) reported in Table 4. Consequently, SE can facilitate the development of LFSCs.

6. Conclusions, implications, and future research agenda

Grounded on stakeholder theoretical lens, in our study, we have explained the nexus of stakeholders and LFSCs' success. Our research outlines that identification of stakeholders is not enough, they need to be prioritized based on their power and interest for successful development of LFSCs. Our analysis signifies that all stakeholders in the "Players" cohort deserve the most attention due to their significant power and interest. "Context setters" should be prioritized next as they can make the context either favorable or unfavorable for chain development. "Subjects" and "Crowds" should be prioritized only after the two former stakeholder groups. Our review of the literature indicates that stakeholders can perform the role of initiator, investor, educator, regulator, and facilitator while orchestrating LFSCs. The role of initiator is unique to "Players". Likewise, the role of regulator is exclusively performed by "Context setters". The other roles are shared among stakeholders, meaning these roles can be performed by several stakeholders. These further highlights the significance of "Players" and "Context setters" in developing successful LFSCs. Our research informs that stakeholders' drivers and barriers vary based on the type of LFSCs they participate in. Self-centric drivers (SCD) of most stakeholders outweigh their altruistic drivers (ALD) when participating in LFSCs. Thus, for the successful development of LFSCs, it is crucial to first satisfy SCD. While producers and customers mostly experience exogenous barriers (XB) arising from external context, other stakeholders, namely organizers, restaurants and government encounter greater endogenous barriers (EB) associated with internal context. Therefore, the successful development of LFSCs requires improvement in both internal and external contexts. Our research further reports that SE assists in fulfilling drivers and overcoming barriers of stakeholders, hence it is vital in the development of LFSCs regardless of their type. However, successful development of indirect-intermediate (IIM) chains requires higher level of engagement from a broader range of stakeholders than other chain types given their complexity and reliance on coordination among multiple actors.

6.1. Theoretical and managerial implications

This literature contributes to the LFSCs literature by synthesizing the scattered findings on interplay between stakeholders and the success of LFSCs into a more coherent and meaningful manner. This is the first SLR that has adopted stakeholder theoretical lens in categorizing stakeholders of LFSCs; thus, this research has broadened the scope of the theory and widened the knowledge base of the investigated phenomenon. By categorizing roles and showing what roles are unique and shared, this research clarifies level of contributions of individual stakeholders in developing LFSCs. Furthermore, this research provides a comprehensive understanding of the drivers and barriers in developing LFSCs by comparing the perspectives of distinct stakeholders across diverse LFSCs in a single study. Categorization of the wide array of drivers and barriers into overarching group has further improved the clarity. Our research demonstrates that satisfaction of self-centric drivers (SCD) is of primary importance for most stakeholders and exogenous barriers (XB) are the main cause that slows down the participation of producers and customers in any LFSC type, thus extending the current LFSC literature.

Our research has the potential for managerial implications. The identification of stakeholders, especially their categorization, inform focal firms, whom and why to prioritize when developing the LFSCs. Moreover, this research offers directories of roles, drivers, and barriers by different stakeholders and types of chains. Identification of stakeholders' roles assists focal firms in understanding the responsibilities of their stakeholders, and with this knowledge, focal firms can approach them in performing these roles when needed. This research provides focal firms insights into which stakeholder has stronger SCD relative to ALD (and vice versa) behind their involvement in the chain. By having this knowledge, managers of focal firm can respond strategically. Furthermore, knowledge of EB and XB encountered by different stakeholder groups while developing different types will enable managers to control and alter them whenever possible. If overcoming a barrier is beyond the firm's control, then it can engage with other stakeholders who have the power to mitigate those barriers.

6.2. Limitations and future research agenda

In our research, we set out to bridge the research gap by understanding the nexus between the stakeholders and LFSCs' success. Nonetheless, this research, like other previous studies, has limitations, thus creating new research gaps and giving direction for future research. First, this study is based on empirical research, but it is not empirical itself. Future research can undertake a theory-testing case study approach to test the validity of the research findings. Second, our research has presented findings from four types of chains and left out other promising chain types such as "Digital platforms", "Retailers", "Wholesalers", and "Food hubs". Future empirical research can be conducted to analyze the stakeholders of these chain types. Third, our research did not consider the role, drivers, and barriers of "Subjects" and "Crowds" stakeholder groups owing to the limited extant research on them. An in-depth empirical analysis of these stakeholder groups is needed. Fourth, there is a lack of research on identifying drivers and barriers related to the "Context setters". Extant literature has identified their drivers and barriers regardless of LFSCs types. Since the findings highlight that they are crucial stakeholders and have significant roles in the successful flourishing of LFSCs, more empirical research is needed to explore their drivers and barriers in different types of chains.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Afshana Saleh: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Per Hilletofth:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clscn.2026.100359.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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